



ROLE PLAY: (from left) Lalitha, Kavya Madhavan, Das in the film

adds. "One of course was to work with somebody like Adoor sir whom I have always admired. I had requested him to give me a role but thought I would never get one because he had never taken any non-Malayali actors except Tanvi Azmi. But I had a hidden agenda too. I wanted to learn how a master director works so that I could copy some of it as I direct my first film now," says Das, speaking from Mumbai where she is neck-deep in work. She starts shooting her first film, a multi-lingual, later this month at Hyderabad. "It is a film about human relationships. I keep all the rest a big suspense although I admit that I have undertaken a project far heavier than I imagined," says Das. She also had the rare privilege of being told about the role in advance by Adoor. "I never knew it was blasphemous for any actor to ask him about one's role or the story. But I did and he was so kind to explain everything

"I wanted to learn how a great director works so that I could copy some of it as I direct my first film."

NANDITA DAS, ACTOR

role reminded her of Jean Luc Godard's classic, *My Life to Live*.

Adoor has added more characters, situations and even sub-texts to the original narrative. "I don't believe in copying the original though Thakazhi is one of my all-time favourites. My films are independent creations," he says, calling *Four Women* his most "minutely choreographed" work. "From four different stories I wanted to create a work with internal cohesion and a sharp focus." While the second story, *The Virgin*, talks about the predicament of a peasant woman (Mohandas) trapped in a loveless marriage, *The Housewife* is about a young homemaker (Pillai) who is unable to bear children, which makes her an object of social ridicule. The fourth, *The Spinster*, brilliantly essayed by Das is about a woman who happens to remain single and is stigmatised by society for doing so.

Unlike the protagonists in the earlier three stories, Kamakshi, the spinster, gradually finds the courage to



ON THE SETS: Adoor with Padmapriya (left) and Sona Nair

pooh-pooh society which looks down upon her. In the process she overcomes her own pangs of self-pity to emerge defiant. She, not just realises, but loudly proclaims to the world that she doesn't care for the institution. Kamakshi's proclamation is Adoor's creative and political addition to the original story.

"I think the woman's painstaking journey towards finding her identity is what attracted me," says Das. "There were two more reasons," she quickly

in detail," she says. Adoor explains he granted the privilege only because she didn't know the language or the local culture. Das adds she was ignorant enough to commit an even greater blasphemy by suggesting a correction in the script, a moment when the whole crew simply stood frozen. "But he was so considerate and confident to accept even that," she laughs.

The film was well received at its world premiere in the Toronto Festival's Masters Section along with films by Eric Rohmer and Claude Chabrol—the screening was repeated four times, every time to full houses. Adoor beams when narrating fellow filmmaker Deepa Mehta's comment in Toronto that she and her daughter could equally enjoy the film. "I am happy that women of different generations can relate to it. It shows that certain essential things have hardly changed with time," he says. The film was also screened at the London Festival and looks all set to satiate the general hunger for an Adoor film—his first after five years.